the full range of meaning implicit in the term. 'English has no equivalent for *dharma*,' writes P. Lal, defining *dharma* as 'code of good conduct, pattern of noble living, religious rules and observance'. Nanditha Krishna, author of several popular books on various aspects of Hinduism, translates *dharma* as 'law of righteousness'. In his book *The Speaking Tree*, Richard Lannoy actually defines *dharma* in nine different ways in different contexts. These include moral law, spiritual order, sacred law, righteousness, and even the sweeping 'totality of social, ethical and spiritual harmony.' Indeed, *dharma* in its classic sense embraces the total cosmic responsibility of both God and Man. My late friend Ansar Hussain Khan, author of the polemical *The Rediscovery of India*, suggested that *dharma* is most simply defined as 'that by which we live'.

The word *dharma* is formed from the Sanskrit root 'dhr', to hold. *Dharma* is therefore that which holds a person or object and maintains it in existence; it is the law that governs its being. To live according to *dharma* is to be in consonance with the truth of things. A moral life, for a Hindu, is a life lived in accordance with his *dharma*, which in turn must be in conformity with the absolute truth that encompasses the universe.

A POLYCENTRIC FAITH

Hinduism is a polycentric faith. Since it admits multiple centres of belief and practice, there is no single structure of theological authority or liturgical power. When there is no centre, there is no periphery either; Sanatana Dharma is inclusive, since there is no basis for excluding any belief. Radhakrishnan argues that Hindu tolerance is not indifference: Hindus understand that not all self-declared truths are of equal value. Still, they are all welcome in that gigantic buffet table of spiritual options the Hindu feels empowered to dip into. Of course, the flip side of the coin is that Hindus tend not to see non-Hindu religious traditions as 'other'; and in particular, they do not see them as challenging or putting into doubt Hindu beliefs and practices, which, after all, are timeless and eternal.

Unlike Hinduism, however, as we have seen, the Semitic (or Abrahamic) faiths believe themselves to be of divine origin. The True